



FACTORS THAT AFFECT FERTILITY

What Is Fertility?

Fertility refers to the ability to conceive a biological child. Many factors can affect fertility in people of all genders, and understanding them can help guide decisions and conversations with healthcare providers.

Factors That Can Affect Female Fertility

- Age: Fertility naturally declines after the mid-30s and more steeply after 40.
- Ovulation disorders: Conditions like PCOS can disrupt regular ovulation.
- Fallopian tube damage: Previous infections (PID), surgeries, or endometriosis can cause scarring.
- Uterine conditions: Fibroids, polyps, or structural issues can affect implantation.
- Thyroid disorders: Both hypothyroidism and hyperthyroidism can disrupt the menstrual cycle.
- Endometriosis: Tissue growth outside the uterus can affect ovarian and tube function.
- Primary ovarian insufficiency: When the ovaries lose normal function before age 40.
- Weight extremes: Both underweight and overweight can affect hormonal balance and ovulation.

Factors That Can Affect Male Fertility

- Low sperm count or poor motility
- Varicocele (enlarged veins in the scrotum)
- Hormonal imbalances
- Previous infections (e.g., mumps, sexually transmitted infections)
- Exposure to heat (laptops, hot tubs) can reduce sperm quality temporarily

Lifestyle Factors Affecting Both Partners

- Smoking significantly reduces fertility in both sexes.
- Excessive alcohol consumption can impair reproductive function.
- High stress levels may affect hormones and ovulation.
- Extreme exercise combined with low body fat can suppress ovulation.
- Certain medications (chemotherapy, steroids, some antidepressants) can affect fertility.

When to Seek a Fertility Evaluation

- Under 35: After 12 months of trying without success
- Ages 35–39: After 6 months without success
- Age 40 or older: Seek evaluation sooner
- Known reproductive health conditions affecting either partner

Key Takeaway

Many factors influence fertility. Early evaluation and a healthy lifestyle can improve chances of conception. A reproductive specialist can help identify and address underlying causes.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by American Society for Reproductive Medicine. (2015). Optimizing natural fertility. Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development. (2022). What causes infertility? Mayo Clinic. (2023). Infertility: Causes.